

Postpaid Billing and Payment Policy

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Overview

The Postpaid Billing and Payment Policy defines how Aether Wireless generates monthly invoices, collects payments, and manages account status for postpaid customers. The policy applies to all postpaid service contracts unless a customer has a written agreement that supersedes these general rules.

Billing Cycle

- Invoices are generated on a recurring basis (typically monthly) for the usage period that has just concluded.
- Each invoice includes a summary of charges, applicable taxes, and any adjustments from the prior billing cycle.

Payment Methods

- Accepted payment methods include electronic bank transfer, credit/debit card, and authorized automatic payment (ACH) arrangements.
- Customers may select one or more methods; the primary method is used first, with secondary methods serving as fallback.

Due Date

- Payment is due on the date specified on the invoice, which is calculated based on the billing cycle end date plus the standard payment period.
- The due date is communicated to the customer via the invoice and any associated electronic notifications.

Failed Payments

- If a payment is not received by the due date, the account is placed in a **past due** status.
- The system automatically attempts a second collection using any secondary payment method on file.
- A notification is sent to the customer outlining the missed payment and next steps.

Account Status Management

- **Current** – Account is in good standing; services continue without interruption.
- **Past Due** – Services remain active but the account is flagged for follow up; additional collection actions may be initiated.
- **Suspended** – If payment remains unresolved after a defined grace period, services may be temporarily suspended pending payment.
- **Terminated** – Persistent non payment may lead to termination of service and recovery actions in accordance with contractual terms.

Customer Responsibilities

- Review each invoice for accuracy and report discrepancies within the timeframe indicated on the invoice.

- Ensure that a valid payment method is on file and that sufficient funds are available on the due date.
- Respond promptly to any payment-related communications from Aether Wireless.

Internal Staff Responsibilities

- Billing staff generate and distribute invoices according to the schedule defined in the system.
- Customer service representatives provide clarification on invoice items and assist with payment method updates.
- Collections team monitors past-due accounts, initiates follow-up actions, and escalates accounts according to the defined status hierarchy.

Scope and Applicability

This section defines the boundaries of the **Postpaid Billing and Payment Policy** (Document ID: BILL-001) and identifies the parties to whom it applies.

• Applicable Services

- All postpaid voice, data, and bundled service plans offered by Aether Wireless.
- Any postpaid add-on features (e.g., international roaming, device financing) that are billed on a monthly basis.

• Customer Eligibility

- The policy applies to every customer who has entered into a postpaid contract with Aether Wireless, regardless of account age, credit tier, or geographic region.
- Customers on prepaid or hybrid (prepay + postpay) plans are excluded; they are governed by the separate Prepaid Billing Policy.

• Geographic Scope

- The policy is enforceable for all Aether Wireless operations worldwide, unless a local regulator mandates a divergent requirement. In such cases, the local regulation supersedes this policy.

• Internal Stakeholder Coverage

- **Billing Operations Team** – responsible for generating invoices, applying payments, and monitoring delinquency.
- **Customer Service Representatives** – handle inquiries, payment arrangements, and escalation of payment issues.
- **Finance Department** – oversees reconciliation, reporting, and compliance with external financial regulations.
- **Legal & Compliance** – reviews any exceptions required by law or regulatory bodies.

• Exceptions

- Accounts that are under a court-ordered payment plan or a government-mandated assistance program are subject to the terms of those specific arrangements, which may modify due dates or payment methods.
- In cases of force-majeure events (e.g., natural disasters) that impact a customer's ability to pay, staff may apply a temporary waiver in accordance with the Force-Majeure Exception Procedure (refer to internal SOP).

• Customer Responsibilities

- Ensure that billing information (address, contact details, and payment method) is current and accurate.
- Review monthly statements promptly and report any discrepancies to the Billing Operations Team within the timeframe specified in the statement.
- Honor the agreed-upon payment schedule unless an approved exception is granted.

• Operational Steps for Determining Applicability

1. Verify that the account type is classified as "postpaid" in the customer master data.

2. Confirm that the service portfolio associated with the account consists solely of postpaid offerings.
3. Check for any active regulatory or legal exceptions linked to the account.
4. If all criteria are met, apply the Postpaid Billing and Payment Policy to the account; otherwise, reference the appropriate alternative policy.

Billing Cycle Rules

Aether Wireless postpaid accounts operate on a recurring billing cycle that defines when charges are calculated, invoiced, and due. The following rules apply to all postpaid customers unless otherwise specified in a customer-specific agreement.

Cycle Definition

- **Cycle Length:** The standard billing cycle is one calendar month. The cycle start date is the date the service is first activated or the date of the most recent plan change.
- **Cycle Alignment:** For customers who change plans mid-cycle, the new plan's charges are prorated for the remainder of the current cycle and then applied to the next full cycle.

Invoicing and Due Date

- **Invoice Generation:** An invoice is generated at the end of each billing cycle and is made available to the customer via the online portal, email, or paper mail, depending on the customer's preference.
- **Due Date:** Payment is due X days after the invoice date. (The exact number of days is defined in the customer contract and is not disclosed here.)

Payment Methods

- Accepted payment methods include:
 - Automated bank debit (ACH)
 - Credit or debit card (Visa, MasterCard, American Express)
 - Online payment through the customer portal
 - Authorized third-party payment processors
- Payments must be processed using the method selected in the customer's account profile. Changes to the payment method require verification and must be updated in the system before the next billing cycle.

Failed Payment Handling

1. **First Failure:** The system attempts a second collection attempt within 24 hours. The customer receives a notification of the failed payment and a reminder of the upcoming due date.
2. **Second Failure:** A second notification is sent, and the account is placed on a **Grace Period** pending resolution.
3. **Grace Period:** During the grace period, services continue without interruption, but the account is flagged for follow-up by the Billing team.
4. **Third Failure:** If payment is not received after the grace period, the account is moved to **Suspended** status in accordance with the Account Status Policy.

Exceptions

- **Promotional Accounts:** Customers enrolled in promotional billing arrangements may have alternate cycle lengths or due dates as defined in the promotion terms.
- **Regulatory Holds:** Accounts subject to regulatory holds (e.g., court orders) follow the specific timelines dictated by the applicable regulation, superseding the standard cycle rules.

Customer Responsibilities

- Keep payment method information current and ensure sufficient funds are available on the due date.
- Review the monthly invoice for accuracy and report any discrepancies within the timeframe specified in the Dispute Resolution Procedure.
- Notify Aether Wireless promptly of any changes to billing address, contact information, or preferred payment method.

Internal Staff Responsibilities

- **Billing Operations:** Generate invoices promptly at cycle end, verify accuracy of prorated charges, and ensure delivery through the selected channel.
- **Customer Service:** Respond to payment-related inquiries, provide assistance with updating payment methods, and communicate any upcoming changes to billing cycles.
- **Collections Team:** Monitor failed payment alerts, execute the defined collection steps, and coordinate with the Account Management team for any required account status changes.

These rules establish a consistent framework for managing postpaid billing cycles, ensuring transparency for customers and operational efficiency for Aether Wireless staff.

Accepted Payment Methods

Aether Wireless supports a defined set of payment methods for postpaid accounts. All methods must be accepted in the currency of the account and comply with applicable regulatory and security standards.

Supported Methods

- **Credit/Debit Cards** – Visa, MasterCard, American Express, and Discover. Card details must be entered through the secure online portal or provided to a billing representative.
- **Electronic Bank Transfer (ACH/EFT)** – Direct debit from a checking or savings account. Customers must submit a signed authorization form.
- **Online Payment Services** – PayPal, Apple Pay, Google Pay, or other approved digital wallets, provided the service is linked to a verified funding source.
- **Postal Money Order** – Accepted only when mailed to the designated billing address with the account number clearly indicated.

Operational Steps

- 1. Customer Initiation** – The customer selects a preferred method via the self-service portal or contacts the Billing Support team.
- 2. Verification** – Billing staff confirm that the payment method meets security and compliance requirements (e.g., card validation, bank account verification).
- 3. Activation** – Once verified, the method is added to the account profile and becomes the default payment option for the next billing cycle.
- 4. Processing** – Payments are processed on the scheduled due date. Successful transactions update the account status automatically.

Exceptions

- **Cash Payments** – Not accepted for postpaid billing due to traceability and reconciliation constraints.
- **International Cards** – May be declined if they do not meet the issuer's cross-border verification standards.

Customer Responsibilities

- Keep payment method information current and accurate.
- Notify Billing Support promptly of any changes to card expiration dates, bank account details, or digital wallet credentials.
- Ensure sufficient funds or credit availability on the payment date to avoid failed transactions.

Internal Staff Responsibilities

- Verify the authenticity and validity of new payment method submissions.
- Record all payment method changes in the customer account system with timestamps and staff identifiers.
- Escalate any payment method that fails verification to the Risk Management team for review.

Compliance with these procedures ensures timely billing, reduces the incidence of failed payments, and maintains the integrity of the postpaid billing cycle.

Payment Due Dates and Grace Period

The postpaid billing cycle ends on the last day of each calendar month. The invoice generated for that cycle is delivered to the customer electronically (or by mail, if requested) within three business days after cycle close. The **payment due date** is set to **15 calendar days** from the invoice issuance date, unless otherwise specified in the customer contract.

Grace Period

A standard grace period of **5 calendar days** follows the due date. Payments received within the grace period are treated as on-time and do not trigger any service restrictions.

Operational Steps

- 1. Invoice Generation** – Billing system creates the invoice and timestamps the issuance date.
- 2. Notification** – Automated notification is sent to the customer with the due date and grace period details.
- 3. Payment Processing** – Payments received before or on the due date are posted as on-time. Payments received during the grace period are posted as on-time but flagged for internal monitoring.
- 4. Grace Period Expiry** – If no payment is recorded by the end of the grace period, the account is flagged for potential delinquency actions.

Exceptions

- **Contractual Variations** – Customers with negotiated billing terms may have a different due date or grace period as documented in their contract. In such cases, the contract terms supersede the standard policy.
- **Regulatory Requirements** – Any jurisdiction-specific regulations that mandate a different grace period must be applied in lieu of the standard 5-day grace period.

Customer Responsibilities

- Review the invoice promptly upon receipt.
- Ensure payment is submitted by the due date to avoid reliance on the grace period.
- Notify the billing department of any changes to contact information that could affect invoice delivery.

Internal Staff Responsibilities

- Verify that invoices are generated and dispatched within the three-business-day window.
- Monitor accounts for payments received during the grace period and update status accordingly.
- Apply any contractual or regulatory exceptions before flagging an account for delinquency.

Failed Payment Process

The Failed Payment Process outlines how Aether Wireless handles postpaid accounts when a scheduled payment is not successfully received. The process applies to all postpaid customers whose payment method (e.g., credit card, bank account, or authorized electronic transfer) fails to clear on the due date.

Applicable Rule

When a payment attempt fails, the account is placed in a **Payment■Failure Status** until the issue is resolved. The status triggers a defined series of notifications, internal actions, and potential service restrictions.

Operational Steps

1. Detection

- The billing system automatically flags a payment as failed at the close of the billing day.

2. Initial Notification

- An automated email and SMS are sent to the customer within 24 hours of the failure, indicating:
- The amount due
- The date of the missed payment
- Instructions for updating payment information or making an alternate payment.

3. Grace Period Monitoring

- The account remains in Payment■Failure Status for a standard grace period (as defined in the broader billing policy). No service interruption occurs during this time.

4. Second Notification

- If the payment remains unresolved after the grace period, a second notification is issued, reiterating the outstanding balance and warning of possible service suspension.

5. Escalation Review

- Billing staff review the account for any recurring issues or potential fraud.
- If the failure appears to be due to a systemic issue (e.g., bank outage), staff may extend the grace period at their discretion.

6. Service Restriction

- If the payment is still not received after the second notification, the account may be moved to **Restricted Service Status**, limiting non■essential services (e.g., data caps, international roaming).

7. Final Notice & Account Closure

- A final notice is sent, outlining the steps required to restore full service.
- If no resolution is achieved within the timeframe specified in the final notice, the account may be scheduled for termination in accordance with the Account Termination Policy.

Exceptions

- **Payment Dispute:** If a customer formally disputes the charge, the account remains in Payment■Failure Status but is exempt from service restriction until the dispute is resolved.
- **Hardship Cases:** For customers who qualify under a documented hardship program, staff may apply a temporary waiver of service restrictions, provided appropriate documentation is received.

Customer Responsibilities

- Review notifications promptly and update payment information or arrange alternate payment methods as instructed.
- Contact the Billing Support Center within the grace period if there are extenuating circumstances preventing payment.
- Respond to any dispute or hardship documentation requests within the specified timeframes.

Internal Staff Responsibilities

- **Billing System Administrators:** Ensure failed payment alerts are generated accurately and trigger the correct notification workflow.
- **Billing Representatives:** Monitor accounts in Payment Failure Status, provide assistance to customers, and document any extensions or exceptions applied.
- **Escalation Team:** Evaluate recurring failures for potential fraud or systemic issues and authorize any necessary adjustments to the grace period.
- **Compliance Officer:** Verify that all actions taken comply with regulatory requirements and internal policy standards.

Account Status Impact

The postpaid account status is directly linked to the customer's payment performance. The following rules define how billing events affect account standing and outline the responsibilities of both customers and internal staff.

General Rule

- **Current** – The account is in good standing when the most recent invoice has been paid in full by the due date.
- **Past Due** – The account moves to past due status when a payment is not received by the invoice due date.
- **Suspended** – The account is suspended when payment remains outstanding after the prescribed grace period and internal escalation procedures have been executed.
- **Terminated** – The account may be terminated if the past due balance remains unresolved following suspension and final notice periods, in accordance with applicable contract terms.

Operational Steps

- 1. Invoice Generation** – Billing system creates the monthly invoice and records the due date.
- 2. Payment Monitoring** – Automated checks flag any invoice that remains unpaid after the due date.
- 3. Grace Period Notification** – Customer receives a reminder notice outlining the past due status and any applicable grace period.
- 4. Escalation** – If payment is still not received, the account is marked as suspended; internal staff initiate suspension procedures per the escalation workflow.
- 5. Final Notice** – A final notice is sent before termination, summarizing the outstanding balance and the impending termination date.
- 6. Termination Processing** – Upon continued nonpayment, staff execute termination actions, including service deactivation and account closure.

Exceptions

- **Disputed Charges** – If a customer formally disputes a charge, the account may remain in current status pending resolution, provided the dispute is documented and a temporary payment arrangement is in place.
- **Approved Payment Arrangements** – When a customer secures an approved payment plan, the account status may be maintained as current for the duration of the arrangement, subject to compliance with the agreed schedule.
- **Regulatory Holds** – Accounts subject to regulatory holds (e.g., court orders) are exempt from automatic suspension and follow the specific legal process.

Customer Responsibilities

- Pay the full invoice amount by the due date unless a formal dispute or approved payment arrangement is in place.
- Respond promptly to any payment reminders or notices.
- Notify the billing department of any changes to payment method or contact information that could affect payment processing.

Internal Staff Responsibilities

- Ensure invoices are generated accurately and delivered on schedule.
- Monitor payment status and trigger notifications according to the defined timeline.
- Document all communications, disputes, and payment arrangements in the customer's account record.
- Follow the escalation workflow consistently, applying exceptions only when documented and authorized.

Exceptions and Waivers

The Postpaid Billing and Payment Policy includes defined circumstances under which standard billing rules may be modified or temporarily suspended. These provisions are intended to balance customer fairness with the operational integrity of Aether Wireless billing systems.

Applicable Rules

- **Waiver Eligibility** – A waiver may be granted when a customer experiences a verifiable service interruption, a documented billing error, or an extraordinary hardship that prevents timely payment.
- **Scope of Waiver** – Waivers may apply to late fees, service suspension, or the requirement to meet a specific payment deadline. They do not alter the underlying service charges for the billing period.

Operational Steps

- 1. Customer Request** – The customer must submit a written request (email or portal ticket) detailing the reason for the waiver, including any supporting documentation (e.g., outage notice, medical certificate, or financial hardship statement).
- 2. Initial Review** – Billing staff reviews the request within a defined internal timeframe and verifies the supporting evidence.
- 3. Decision** –
 - If approved, the staff records the waiver in the billing system, notes the effective dates, and communicates the outcome to the customer.
 - If denied, the staff provides a clear explanation and outlines any alternative assistance options.
- 4. Documentation** – All waiver decisions are logged with the request ID, reviewer name, and justification to ensure auditability.

Exceptions

- **System-Generated Errors** – When an automated billing error is identified (e.g., duplicate charge), the error is corrected without requiring a formal waiver request.
- **Regulatory Mandates** – Any statutory requirement that overrides standard billing practices (e.g., emergency consumer protection orders) is applied automatically, superseding internal waiver procedures.
- **Promotional Adjustments** – Temporary promotional credits or discounts are handled under the promotions policy and are not considered waivers.

Customer Responsibilities

- Provide accurate and complete information in the waiver request.
- Respond promptly to any follow-up inquiries from billing staff.
- Honor any revised payment schedule communicated as part of the waiver approval.

Internal Staff Responsibilities

- Assess waiver requests objectively and consistently, adhering to documented criteria.
- Maintain confidentiality of customer information throughout the review process.
- Ensure that any granted waiver is reflected accurately in the billing system to prevent future billing disputes.
- Escalate complex or high-value cases to the Billing Manager for final approval.

Roles and Responsibilities

Customer Responsibilities

- Review the monthly invoice promptly and verify all listed charges.
- Submit payment by the due date using an approved payment method (e.g., electronic funds transfer, credit/debit card, or authorized bank draft).
- Notify the Billing Department of any billing discrepancies, address changes, or payment method updates within five business days of discovery.
- Maintain sufficient funds or credit availability to cover the full invoice amount to avoid service interruptions.

Billing Department Responsibilities

- Generate accurate postpaid invoices on the scheduled billing cycle and distribute them to customers via the designated delivery channels (email, portal, or paper).
- Record all received payments in the billing system no later than the business day following receipt.
- Monitor accounts for missed or failed payments and initiate the defined escalation process (e.g., reminder notices, temporary service suspension) according to the policy workflow.
- Communicate any billing errors or adjustments to the customer promptly and provide a corrected invoice when necessary.

Finance Operations Responsibilities

- Reconcile daily payment transactions against bank statements and the internal accounting ledger.
- Ensure that all payment methods comply with applicable regulatory and security standards.
- Prepare periodic reports on payment performance, delinquency trends, and revenue recognition for senior management review.

Customer Service Responsibilities

- Serve as the first point of contact for customers with billing inquiries, providing clear explanations of charges and payment options.
- Escalate unresolved payment issues to the Billing Department according to the established escalation matrix.
- Document all customer interactions related to billing in the CRM system to maintain an audit trail.

IT/Systems Support Responsibilities

- Maintain the integrity and availability of the billing platform, ensuring that invoice generation, payment processing, and account status updates function without interruption.

- Implement and test backup and recovery procedures for billing data in accordance with the company's data protection policies.

Compliance and Audit Responsibilities

- Conduct regular audits of billing processes to verify adherence to internal policies and external regulatory requirements.
- Report any identified non-compliance or systemic issues to the Compliance Officer for corrective action.

These responsibilities collectively ensure accurate billing, timely payment collection, and consistent service delivery for postpaid accounts.

Key Rules Summary

Rule	Requirement	Operational Handling
Billing Cycle Frequency	Postpaid accounts are billed on a regular recurring cycle.	System generates an invoice at the start
Accepted Payment Methods	Payments may be made using approved methods (e.g., credit/debit card, ACH, online portal).	Payment gateway validates method; suc
Payment Due Date	All invoices must be paid by the due date specified on the invoice.	Automated reminders are sent prior to th
Late Payment Consequence	Late payment triggers a defined follow-up process.	System flags overdue invoices, applies a
Failed Payment Procedure	If a payment attempt fails, the system must retry and notify the customer.	Automatic retry is scheduled; failure trigg
Account Suspension Trigger	Accounts with unresolved payment issues may be suspended.	After the defined escalation period, the sy
Reactivation Requirement	Suspended accounts can be reactivated upon receipt of payment.	Once payment clears, the system restore
Billing Dispute Handling	Customers may dispute charges within the policy-defined window.	Dispute tickets are created, and billing ac

FAQs

- Q:** What is the typical billing cycle for a postpaid account? **A:** Postpaid accounts are billed on a regular monthly cycle, with each cycle covering the usage and services provided during the preceding month.
- Q:** Which payment methods are accepted for postpaid bills? **A:** Accepted payment methods include electronic funds transfer, credit or debit cards, and approved online payment portals. All methods must be linked to a valid account.
- Q:** When is the payment due for a postpaid invoice? **A:** Payment is due on the date specified on the invoice, which is generally a set number of days after the billing cycle ends. The due date will be clearly indicated on each statement.
- Q:** What happens if a payment is missed or fails? **A:** A missed or failed payment triggers a notification to the account holder. If the issue is not resolved within the grace period outlined in the notice, the account may be placed on a delinquent status, potentially affecting service continuity.
- Q:** How does a missed payment affect account status? **A:** Repeated missed payments can lead to the account being classified as delinquent, which may result in service suspension, additional collection actions, or termination as defined by the billing policy.
- Q:** Can I set up automatic payments for my postpaid bill? **A:** Yes, customers may enroll in automatic payment options using a supported payment method to ensure timely settlement of each invoice.
- Q:** How can I view or dispute a charge on my postpaid bill? **A:** Billing statements are accessible through the customer portal. Disputes should be submitted in writing within the timeframe indicated on the invoice, following the outlined dispute resolution process.
- Q:** Who should I contact for billing inquiries or assistance? **A:** For any billing-related questions, customers should contact the Billing Department using the contact information provided on their invoice or through the official Aether Wireless support channels.